are already late." But his aim is not to keep up with the Bidens and Macrons. Chandrasekhar says Modi told him, "I want to use technology to transform the governance narrative of India, and I want it to impact lives. We must embrace tech not just to make unicorns or billionaires but to ensure that the last man in the queue sees its benefits."

After the successful moon landing of Chandrayaan-3 on August 23 this year (India joins an exclusive club of only four space-faring nations to have achieved the feat), Modi called up Union MoS for science and technology Jitendra Singh. He wanted Singh to hold a national quiz so that children would be motivated to learn more about space sciences. Within a month of launching the quiz, Singh's department received over half a million responses. In May, the prime minister formalised India's space policy that broke the monopoly of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) and permitted the private sector to build satellites, rockets and launchers on their own. He even allowed them to use ISRO facilities to do so. Singh says, "The prime minister has the courage and conviction to break taboos of the past and believes in synergy between the public and private sectors. He wants all stakeholders onboard."

THE GROWTH KING

Modi is acutely aware that providing jobs and enhancing per capita income is key to the nation's development and the BJP's continuance as the ruling party. That's where his avatar as Modi the Growth King kicks in. To offset the Covid-induced devastation to the Indian economy, the PM, rather than handing out doles, decided to give a massive boost to infrastructure spending to spur growth and create jobs. Modi points out that in budget 2023-24 capital investment outlay has gone up steeply to Rs 10 lakh crore, a far cry from 2013-14 when it was only Rs 1.88 lakh crore. He asserts that infrastructure creation, be it highways, airports or a railway connection, has been "happening at a never-seen-before pace".



MAKING HISTORY
Modi with women MPs after the passage of the women's reservation bill in the Rajya Sabha, Sept. 21

PTI

"Modi*ji* could be 80,000 feet above sea level," says Union minister Rajeev Chandrasekhar, "but he backs every vision with his feet on the ground"

The result of all this is that India, for the second year, continues to be the fastest growing economy in the world. In October, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) estimated that India's real GDP would be above 6 per cent in 2023 and 2024, putting its annual compounded growth rate above China's 4-5 per cent (the global economy was looking at 3 per cent with advanced economies like the US averaging 1.5 per cent). Modi dismisses the Opposition's allegations of jobless growth and rising inflation, rolling out numbers to prove his case. He points out that the unemployment rate has declined from